

Notorynchus

no-toe-RIN-cuss



Single *Notorynchus* tooth

- **When** 56 million years ago to now
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Cool, shallow marine waters
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Sharks, rays, fish, seals, and dead animals

Also known as the seven gill shark, *Notorynchus* had seven gill slits (unlike the five seen in most sharks). Its strange teeth were each made up of many small points (cusps), creating a jagged, sawlike edge ideal for slicing flesh. *Notorynchus* is still found today and is common in cooler seas worldwide.



Squalicorax

SKWA-lih-CORE-ax



- **When** 105–65 million years ago (Mid to Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 15 ft (4.5 m)
- **Diet** Marine creatures

Fossilized shark teeth are common, since sharks shed thousands of teeth during their lives. Many *Squalicorax* teeth have been found, including one embedded in the foot of a hadrosaurid dinosaur. The rare find shows that *Squalicorax* sometimes scavenged from carcasses washed into the sea.



Stethacanthus

steth-a-CAN-thus

- **When** Late Devonian to Early Carboniferous
- **Fossil location** N. America, Scotland
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 5 ft (1.5 m)
- **Diet** Marine animals

One of the oddest of all prehistoric fish, *Stethacanthus* had a dorsal fin shaped like an ironing board, with a cluster of toothlike scales (denticles) on top. It had more toothlike scales on its head, and its side fins had long, pointed rods called whips trailing behind them. These features may have been present only in males



and were perhaps important in mating. *Stethacanthus* usually lurked in shallow, coastal waters, where it nosed around for small fish and shellfish.

EARLY VERTEBRATES

Helicoprion

HELL-ee-coe-PRY-on

- **When** Early Permian
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 18 ft (5.5 m)
- **Diet** Marine animals

This bizarre shark was named *Helicoprion* ("spiral saw") because the teeth of its lower jaw grew in a spiral, forming a disk as big

as a dinner plate. Only *Helicoprion's* teeth have been found. The disk is known to be from the lower jaw, but how the shark used it to feed is a mystery.

